

Board 1

South Deals

None Vul

♠ 6 3
♥ J 10 9 8 2
♦ Q 10 2
♣ 9 7 4

♠ K J 4

♥ Q 6

♦ 8 5 3

♣ J 10 6 3 2

	N	
W		E
	S	

♠ 10 8 7 5 2

♥ K 4

♦ K 9 7

♣ Q 8 5

♠ A Q 9

♥ A 7 5 3

♦ A J 6 4

♣ A K

West	North	East	South
			2♣
Pass	2NT	Pass	3NT
All Pass			
3NT by North			

North is to play 3NT. East leads the ♠5.

Winners: ♠=3 ♥=1 ♦=1 ♣=2 Total = 7

Needing two winners you will naturally consider your 5-card ♣ suit. After unblocking the ♣ A K you will need two entries to your hand; one to lead the ♣J and drive out the ♣Q, then a second to enjoy your good ♣s.

The ♠ suit will provide one entry easily, but should you depend on the ♥Q for the second entry?

No, for two reasons. Firstly the ♥Q only gives you a 50% chance of being an entry. But more importantly, you already have your two sure entries in ♠s. As long as you take the first trick with dummy's ♠A both your ♠K and ♠J can be entries.

Win the ♠A. Play off dummy's ♣ A K. Lead the ♠9 to your ♠J. Play your ♣J (and another one if necessary) to establish the ♣ suit. Win whatever red card they play next with dummy's Ace. Play the ♠Q to your ♠K and cash your established ! C(s). Dummy's other red Ace will be your ninth trick.

The more you make a point of looking for entries the easier they are to find.

You'd have to be very careless to miss this one.

Board 2

West Deals

N-S Vul

♠ 10 7
♥ 8 6 5
♦ K Q 7 3
♣ J 9 4 2

♠ K J 9 2
♥ Q 10 9 3
♦ 10 9 5 2
♣ 6

	N	
W		E
	S	

♠ A 6 4 3
♥ A J 4
♦ A J
♣ A K 8 3

♠ Q 8 5
♥ K 7 2
♦ 8 6 4
♣ Q 10 7 5

West	North	East	South
Pass	Pass	2NT	Pass
3NT			
All Pass			

3NT by East

Then unblock your ♦ A J. Next play ♣ K. (on which North discards), and a small ♣ toward dummy's ♣ J 9. You are sure to have a ♣ entry to dummy's ♦ s, and you will still get three ♣ tricks, just a different three.

Suppose the opening lead had been a ♦ rather than a ♣.

You probably would have played the hand the same way you just did, unblock ♦ s, then play ♣ A K and a low ♣ toward the ♣ J 9 trying to get a ♣ entry to dummy.

It is only because the ♣ opening lead gives you the chance for a Cheap-Trick that you are tempted to go wrong.

East is to play 3NT. South leads the ♣ 5. You play low from dummy and North plays the ♣ 6.

Winners: ♠ = 1 ♥ = 1 ♦ = 4? ♣ = 3 Total = 9

Although you have 4 ♦ winners, getting to the last couple might not be so easy. You can make 3 ♦ tricks simply by winning your ♦ A, then overtaking your ♦ J with dummy's ♦ Q. But you need that fourth ♦ winner. Can you get it?

Sure you can, by creating an entry in ♣ s. It is likely from the opening lead, (and North's play of a small card), that South has led from ♣ Q 10 7 5. If you win the first trick cheaply then you will still make your ♣ A K for three ♣ tricks in all.

So don't win cheaply, win the first trick with the ♣ A. Then unblock your ♦ A J. Next play ♣ K. (on which North discards), and a small ♣ toward dummy's ♣ J 9. You are sure to have a ♣ entry to dummy's ♦ s, and you will still get three ♣ tricks, just a different three.

Board 3

North Deals

None Vul

♠ Q J 10 9 5

♥ A 9 3

♦ 9 8 3

♣ 10 8

♠ 8 3

♥ J 7 4

♦ A 6 4 2

♣ 7 6 5 3

	N	
W		E
	S	

♠ K 7 4 2

♥ Q 10 8 6

♦ 10 7

♣ K 9 2

♠ A 6

♥ K 5 2

♦ K Q J 5

♣ A Q J 4

West

North

East

South

Pass

3NT

Pass

2NT

All Pass

3NT by South

Maybe in ♦s. Play the ♦K, then ♦Q, watching the defender's cards carefully. When both follow twice you know there is only a single ♦ left out, so you play the ♦J to dummy's ♦A. Now take the ♣ finesse. It works! Next play your ♦5 to dummy's ♦6 and take another ♣ finesse. Both defenders follow so your ♣s are good.

If the ♦s split 4-1 you would have found out when you cashed the ♦K Q.

Then your chance of success goes way down. You would have to find East with the doubleton ♣K.

South is to play 3NT. West leads the ♠Q. East plays the ♠K, then the ♠2 when you hold up.

Winners: ♠=1 ♥=0 ♦=4 ♣=1 Total = 6

You are going to have to be pretty lucky to make this contract. You cannot touch the ♥ suit because a defender would take the ♥A and it would start raining ♠s.

So you will have to get 3 extra ♣ winners, which means the ♣ finesse absolutely MUST work.

In addition to lucky, you are going to have to be pretty good, too. You will surely have to finesse the ♣s at least twice; that means you need two dummy entries. Can you find them?

Board 4

West Deals

Both Vul

♠ -	♠ J 8 6 2	♠ A K Q 7 3
♥ A 5 2	♥ Q 9 8	♥ 7 6 4
♦ A K 6	♦ Q J 10 2	♦ 8 5 3
♣ A K Q J 7 5 4	♣ 10 3	♣ 9 8
	♠ 10 9 5 4	
	♥ K J 10 3	
	♦ 9 7 4	
	♣ 6 2	

West	North	East	South
2♣	Pass	2♠	Pass
3♣	Pass	3NT	Pass
6♣			
All Pass			
6♣ by West			

West is to play 6♣. North leads the ♦Q.

Losers: ♠=0 ♥=2 ♦=1 ♣=0 Total = 3

Partner's hand didn't turn out to be what you hoped for, you had in mind maybe the ♥K and ♦Q.

But this is what you got. First, be thankful North led a ♦ rather than a ♥. Second, see if you can find a way to fight yourself over to dummy and those three beautiful ♠s.

You have two possibilities for a ♣ entry, but you can only try one of them as you will see.

You can play a high ♣ and hope somebody plays the singleton ♣10. Then your ♣9 would be an entry. If this works you would probably make all 13 tricks, but the chances are very slim.

You can play a low ♣ to dummy's ♣8. Assuming a defender takes the ♣10 you can win his return and enter dummy with the ♣9. This play is guaranteed to give you the entry and is the one you should choose.

Just in case you were wondering about the chances of that singleton ♣10, here is how you would figure it out.

When you are missing 4 cards the probability of a 3-1 split is about 50%.

But the singleton can be any one of four cards - in this case it can be the ♣10, ♣6, ♣3 or ♣2. So the chance of one of the opponents holding specifically the singleton ♣10 is only one-fourth of 50%, about 12.5%.

Board 5

North Deals

N-S Vul

♠ Q 10 6 5 2
 ♥ 6 5 2
 ♦ A Q 7
 ♣ 9 4

♠ 8 3
 ♥ A K J 9 8 7
 ♦ K 10 4 3
 ♣ A

	N	
W		E
	S	

♠ A K J 7 4
 ♥ 3
 ♦ J 9 8 2
 ♣ 10 6 2

♠ 9
 ♥ Q 10 4
 ♦ 6 5
 ♣ K Q J 8 7 5 3

West	North	East	South
	1♥	Pass	2♣
Pass	3♥	Pass	4♥

All Pass

4♥ by North

♦. If East plays a third ♠ you will ruff in your hand, then unblock the ♣A, then pull trumps in 3 rounds ending in dummy. And run all those ♣ tricks. If East plays a trump or a ♣ the result will be the same. The defense can get one ♦ trick if they take it right now, but you still make your contract.

It is an important concept. When you have to use a trump as a later entry you could thwart your own plan by ruffing.

North is to play 4♥. East leads the ♠A, then ♠K.

Losers: ♠ = 1 ♥ = 0 ♦ = 3? ♣ = 0 Total = 4?

This is the kind of hand that can get really messy if you aren't careful. You could ruff the ♠, then try to ruff some ♦s, but the defense can prevent you by leading trumps when you give up the ♦ tricks.

All in all a much better plan is to use dummy's ♣ suit after you unblock the Ace. The only flaw with that idea is that when you ruff the ♠, unblock the ♣A, then play two rounds of trumps ending in dummy, there will still be a trump left out. And the defender might ruff a ♣ before you can take the discards you need. Do you see a way around this?

Do NOT ruff the second ♠ in dummy, just discard a